

QUIET DOER

Since taking charge of the railways ministry two years ago, Vaishnaw has been busy removing bottlenecks to speed up reforms

By Anilesh S. Mahajan

IN JULY 2021, WHEN PRIME MINISTER NARENDRA MODI hand-picked Ashwini Vaishnaw, a former IAS officer, to head the railways ministry, the brief given to him was very clear—not only did he have to eliminate the bottlenecks that were hindering reforms, but also ensure that change was visible on the ground. Vaishnaw wasted no time in putting the new and faster Vande Bharat trains on track and kickstarting the makeover of India's railway stations. The plan to let private players run trains—championed by his predecessors Suresh Prabhu and Piyush Goyal—was given a quiet burial, with Vaishnaw pushing for private money to be put into creating capital goods for the national transporter.

"We are building an enabling environment for collaborations and partnerships...to strengthen our capabilities," Vaishnaw told INDIA TODAY. "Private capital is welcome [in that field]." The minister said that work is in progress to make railways "more efficient, more comfortable for the consumer and aligned to modern technology". And the indigenously developed and manufactured semi-high-speed Vande Bharat Express trains are central to this plan, spreading their network at a time when Prime Minister Narendra Modi's dream of bullet trains is yet to get off the track. Since flagging off the first Vande Bharat train between Delhi and Varanasi just ahead of the parliamentary election in 2019, 19 more have been added to the railways' roster, and another 67 are expected to chug off in FY24.

Things aren't going perhaps as fast

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>
> **ASHWINI VAISHNAW**
> *Union railways minister*